SPORTS

MAKING A BIG IMPACT FOR BEARS

How Jeffery Simmons weaves a sudden impact into the game in ways both obvious and subtle. Plus, Kalif Raymond has established himself as great teammate and playmaker.

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Chicago Tribune

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‘There’s still so much danger’

Domestic violence homicides drop but attacks with guns rise

By Caroline Kubzansky
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A few weeks before Crystal Salter was shot and killed, she threw her 7-year-old daughter a K-pop themed birthday party — the kind of huge celebration she had always wanted to mark special occasions with.

She was big on Halloween and other holidays, her sister Regina Salter said. She took her daughter everywhere with her and had been thrilled to start fostering another little girl in April.

Both girls were in bed with Salter on Sept. 6 when her boyfriend allegedly shot and killed her. He was found in his car a few blocks away on the Near West Side, dead of a gunshot wound to his mouth, which was ruled a suicide. Crystal Salter’s family said police have closed the case and have not considered any other suspects in her death.

Salter is one of at least 28 people killed at the hands of a family member or intimate partner so far in 2026.

That number represents a significant decrease from the same period last year when a spike in homicides turned up the volume on an alarm that had been ringing since the beginning of the pandemic. But at the same time, domestic attacks involving guns have increased this year, leaving law enforcement, advocates and other criminal justice stakeholders taking stock of a complicated year.

Regina Salter said her sister’s killing came out of the blue.

“If there were some type of domestic violence going on and she told us, we would have encouraged her to leave the situation,” she said. “But sometimes it’s hard to leave or scary to leave.”

Sometimes, as in Salter’s case, there’s no obvious sign to the family that someone is in danger. Other times there are indicators

See **VIOLENCE** on Page A4

ELECTION 2026



Illinois’ next U.S. senator, Lt. Gov. Juliana Stratton, greets Sen. Tammy Duckworth alongside Gov. JB Pritzker on Wednesday as they celebrate election victories and unveil an agenda for the years ahead at the Columbus Park Refectory in Chicago. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Blue blood, new blood

Illinois’ congressional Democrats, with 6 new faces, vow to balance oversight of Trump with delivering results in wake of Tuesday’s transformative election

By Olivia Olander and Dan Petrella
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Judging only by the maps of congressional election results, it would appear last week’s Democratic wave bypassed Illinois as it swept across the country, turning new and unfamiliar places blue from South Carolina to northern Nevada.

After Tuesday’s transformative midterm elections, the partisan makeup of Illinois’ delegation is unchanged: Both U.S. senators and 14 of 17 House members will be Democrats.

■ A new CPS board takes shape, with big decisions ahead. **Page A2**
■ How Trump effect grew Dems’ suburban footprint. **Page A6**
■ Marchers take to streets with hope after “blue wave.” **Page A9**
■ Trump’s grip on the Republican Party now in question. **Page B5**

When the new Congress convenes in January, however, six of those seats — one in the Senate and five in the House — will have new occupants. The turnover marks a generational, if not ideological, shift in the state’s Democratic representation in Washington as the party assumes its largest congressional majorities since before the tea party “shellacking” of 2010.

With two years remaining in President Donald Trump’s term, there’s a broad consensus among Illinois’ congressional Democrats, from the political center to the left flank, that their newly empowered and emboldened party must balance two responsibilities: It has to serve as a check on the administration while also addressing the economic anxieties and corruption concerns that fueled a stunning midterm rebuke of Republicans.

“Americans sent a very, very clear message: They are sick of Donald Trump’s bull---- ... promising one thing in the morning but going back on his word by the afternoon,” Sen. Tammy Duckworth said Wednesday, a day after Democrats gained at least 41 House seats and at least seven in the Senate. “And they are done with him putting self-interest over our national interest.”

Duckworth wasn’t on the ballot, but the two-term Hoffman Estates Democrat will become the state’s senior senator next year with the

See **ELECTION** on Page A8

Runway taxi times at O’Hare among worst in nation



A United Airlines jet taxis on a runway at O’Hare International Airport in 2025. O’Hare averaged 20 minutes for jets to taxi to their gates. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

“It’s kind of like driving up into your garage, or driving up into your driveway at home, and then they don’t let you out of the car.”

DENNIS TAJER, an O’Hare-based American Airlines pilot and spokesperson for its pilots union

By Talia Soglin
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Chicago can look tantalizing from the window of an airplane on its descent into O’Hare International Airport.

But much to the chagrin of air travelers who might glimpse the city’s skyline rising over Lake Michigan on their way in, touching down at O’Hare isn’t exactly the same as arriving. That’s because taxi times at the airport are longer, on average, than those at almost every other major airport in the country.

“It’s kind of like driving up into your garage, or driving up into your driveway at home, and then they don’t let you out of the car,” said Dennis Tajer, an O’Hare-based American Airlines pilot and spokesperson for its pilots union.

From January through the end of August this year — the most recent month for which Federal Aviation Administration data is available — planes landing at O’Hare averaged 20 minutes to taxi to their gates once their wheels hit the ground. No other major U.S. airport reported

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INSIDE



EILEEN T. MESLAR/TRIBUNE

With Welch out, who will be next speaker?

With women expected to make up more than half of the likely 85-member Democratic caucus in Springfield, there is the potential they could elect the state’s first woman House speaker. **Chicagoland, Page A3**

Style embodies futurism, optimism

A hundred years ago, Art Deco emerged, an exuberant style that spans architecture, interior design, artwork and even type fonts. And it is the subject of a new book by a Chicago architectural historian. **Arts & Entertainment**

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